PILGRIMAGE

CASTING SIDES

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Director: Khaled Abol Naga (Kal)

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HOW TO USE THESE SIDES

Each side has been selected to reveal character, range, and presence within 1–2 minutes of screen time. Please read all instructions on your character's page before recording.

Slate first. At the top of your video, look directly into the camera and state your name, pronouns, the role you are reading for, and your city.

Video format. Horizontal (landscape), MP4, 1080p or 720p preferred. Maximum 500MB. Good light on your face, quiet background. No production quality required.

If reading for multiple roles, **submit a separate video per character.**

Dialogue sides (Nadia). Nadia's sides include a brief dialogue exchange. Simply skip or pause over the other character's lines — the director will read between the lines.

Submit your tape via the link at: kalnaga.com/pilgrimage/casting.html

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THE CHARACTERS IN THIS DOCUMENT

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NOOR · She/her · Early 60s · Afghan American

> **Director note:** *What I'm looking for: the weight of a woman who has carried this secret for decades, and the terrifying relief of finally putting it down. Let the pauses breathe. Don't rush the confession. The scene lives in what she can barely bring herself to say.*

SLATE INSTRUCTION *Before beginning, look directly into camera and state: your full name · your pronouns · the role you are reading for (NOOR) · your location. Maximum total video: 2 minutes.*

THE SIDE — Noor's Confession (Act II, Scene 4)

Setting: At the Kaaba, Mecca. Noor addresses Maryam directly for the first time.

You know I've called you my miracle child, Maryam. I had such trouble conceiving. I thought it was my fault, that I was the cause. But I wasn't.

Right after the Russians invaded Afghanistan, they were rounding up anyone who was not a communist sympathizer. They took your father—my husband—in for interrogation. People didn't return home to their families after these types of arrests. After two weeks of no information, no answers, I thought the worst. I fell into a deep depression. I couldn't see that life was worth living without him. Almas got concerned. She was pregnant with Nadia, so she took precautions and sent her husband to bring me to their house. It was a way to protect me in case the secret police came after me as well.

My brother-in-law arrived late in the day. There was a curfew at dusk. People were shot if they violated it. No questions asked. So, he spent the night. We didn't intend for it to happen, but…

Maryam, after my husband was released from prison, he was so happy to hear I was pregnant. He showered me with gifts and constantly talked about names. Did you know he only picked girl names? He said boys are useless. His joy was a reminder of my betrayal so I pushed him away.

Maryam, believe me, I have hated myself for lying to him…but I had no choice. Life under communist rule was unbearable. We decided to leave Afghanistan. We escaped out of our own country like thieves. Being homeless and without direction was no time to confess my sin. It would have broken my sister's heart, her marriage, my marriage. I took a daughter from one man and gave her to another.

That is the truth, Maryam. All of your grievances against me…they're all valid. I stole your chance to be loved by your real father, I pushed the only father you knew out of our life and I stole from you the joy of having sisters. I lived with the burden of knowing that you deserved a better mother than me.

MARYAM · She/her · Mid-30s · Afghan American

Director note: *What I'm looking for: Maryam's comedy and Maryam's devastation are the same instrument. I want to see both. Side A shows us the armour — the wit, the control, the performance. Side B shows us what's underneath when the armour is ripped off. If you can, do both. If time is tight, choose the one that surprises you more.*

SLATE INSTRUCTION *Before beginning, look directly into camera and state: your full name · your pronouns · the role you are reading for (MARYAM) · your location. Maximum total video: 2 minutes.*

SIDE A — The Phone Call (Act I, Scene 5)

Setting: Hotel lobby, on the phone with her assistant Candace. She is in Ihram — the sacred white pilgrim's garment.

[speaking on phone]

Candace, I'm about to embark on a journey that Prophet Muhammad, Peace Be Upon Him, made in 632 to retake Mecca. So, tell their lawyers that I'm in the state of Ihram and can't be bothered with earthly problems. They should stop shitting their pants and talk to my lawyers.

I-H-R-A-M. Make sure it's spelled right in the press release.

Candace, I don't care how mad they are. I'm the customer. I don't care if they get a fine. Tell them we had to suffer in a cramped taxi to keep ourselves on schedule. In fact, they should pay me back the taxi fare. Tell them Silicon Valley is full of rich Muslims and once they read my scathing review of their bad service, they will be done for. In fact, I'll write a letter to the Prince to ban the agency from doing trips to Saudi Arabia.

Look, I know you can handle this, Candace. We are about to do the most important part of the Umrah. Try not to disturb me.

SIDE B — The Aftermath (Act II, Scene 4)

Setting: After Noor's confession at the Kaaba. Maryam speaks to herself, in shock.

I can't talk to her right now.

I can't believe this. She's been lying all her life. My whole life is a lie. She fed me this "miracle child" lie.

I really thought I was special.

She brainwashed me against him. She would say, "Your father is too nice, people walk all over him. They take advantage of him. Don't be like him. You have to be strong." He worshiped the ground she walked on and she just shit all over him.

I'm a public figure. I've told and retold my family story to journalists, to world leaders, and it was a lie.

NADIA · She/her · Mid-30s · Afghan American

> **Director note:** *Nadia is the most layered and — honestly — the most challenging role to cast because she has no single long monologue in the current draft. What I need to see: range. The biting sarcasm of Side A followed by the sudden, terrifying vulnerability of the reveal. Then the raw grief and anger of Side B. Take your time between the two sides — let the shift register. Note: H&B are aware that Nadia may need a new monologue in revision.*

SLATE INSTRUCTION *Before beginning, look directly into camera and state: your full name · your pronouns · the role you are reading for (NADIA) · your location. Maximum total video: 2 minutes.*

SIDE A — Boo-hoo + The Reveal (Act II, Scene 4)

Setting: At the Kaaba. Nadia responds to Maryam's self-pity — then makes her own confession.

Boo-hoo, the poor misunderstood millionaire. I may not be famous, but my life is stressful too.

I'd switch places with you any day, Maryam. Any goddamn day. I run a business I don't care about. My marriage is ending. I'm in love with a woman. I don't know what I'm doing with my life. I just found out my Baba—a man I loved and respected more than anyone—went behind my mother's back with my own aunt. My world is falling apart around me.

Everyone was always comparing us. "Are you going to Stanford like your cousin?" "When are you going to follow your dreams Nadia?" They even said we looked alike. Guess now we know why. And yes, I—

I'm in love with Fatima.

SIDE B — You Missed Her Funeral (Act I, Scene 2)

Setting: Hotel room in Medina. Nadia confronts Sosan. (Skip Sosan's lines — the director will read between the lines.)

You missed her funeral.

Everyone was wondering where you were. I had to explain over and over that you were in Nigeria. Do you even understand how bad we looked to Ibrahim's family and our community? And why did you go to Nigeria after her diagnosis? Is taking photographs that important?

You stole my chance to grieve.

I don't want to be in this room with you. You stay on your side. Don't talk to me, don't look at me.

You know what? You can have it. The whole room.

SOSAN · She/her · Early 30s · Afghan American

Director note: *Sosan is the play's comic heartbeat and its most surprising tender soul. This monologue has everything — wit, deflection, sadness, a rant about toothpaste commercials. What I'm looking for: the comedy is real, not performed. The grief underneath it is also real, and it surfaces despite her, not because of a choice to 'get emotional'. Let her surprise herself.*

SLATE INSTRUCTION *Before beginning, look directly into camera and state: your full name · your pronouns · the role you are reading for (SOSAN) · your location. Maximum total video: 2 minutes.*

THE SIDE — The Mundane (Act I, Scene 2)

Setting: Hotel room in Medina. Sosan talks — to herself, to whoever will listen.

I'm…running a little low on hope. My life's kind of off-track right now. A couple of bad relationships… And then my last gallery opening didn't go quite as planned. Okay, it flopped. One reviewer called it "mundane." As if that's a bad thing. Mundane means "of this world," you know? I want to show the world the way it is. I hate pretentious photos, where it's obvious it took hundreds of hours to get the perfect shot. But maybe that's what people want. People want illusions. Perfect family photos where the kids aren't whining or picking their noses. Wedding shots where every zit on the couple's faces is photoshopped out and their teeth are gleaming a shade of white that only exists in toothpaste commercials. Those commercials bug me. They always show someone with perfect teeth consulting with their dentist. Like, why are you wasting your time? You don't need new toothpaste. Show me people with rotten teeth and bleeding gums at the dentist. That'll make me pay attention.

Anyway, my therapist says I have to process my trauma... I hoped coming here would give me clarity. But when I pick up my camera nothing moves me.

FATIMA · She/her · Mid-30s · Black American

> **Director note:** *Fatima is the play's steadiest presence — and then she falls apart in the most private, specific way. I want both sides because they reveal her range: Side A shows the warmth and humour that make her the group's anchor. Side B shows what happens when that anchor loses its hold. The specificity of "we ordered the same kind of tea" is everything — let the small details carry the devastation.*

SLATE INSTRUCTION *Before beginning, look directly into camera and state: your full name · your pronouns · the role you are reading for (FATIMA) · your location. Maximum total video: 2 minutes.*

SIDE A — The Phone Call (Act I, Scene 2)

Setting: Hotel room in Medina. Fatima calls her father.

[speaking on phone]

Hi Dad!

Yeah, it was fine. We just got to our hotel in Medina.

Yeah, it's beautiful. I can see why it's called the Grand Mosque. The towers, they're made of 22 karat gold paint. I'm sorry you'll never get to see it. Unless you convert, too.

I'm joking, Dad. I know Jesus is your man.

A couple of days, and then it's on to Mecca. Is Mom still mad at me?

I wish she would tell me that. I hate it when she's not talking to me.

I know. Tell her it's all good here. It feels super safe. I'll call you when we get to Mecca, okay? Thanks for checking on Cle-cle for me. I love you, Dad.

SIDE B — The Woman in Mecca (Act II, Scene 2)

Setting: Hotel room in Mecca. Fatima tells Nadia what just happened.

She was…nice. Sweet. Happy to meet a young convert. She looks even more like me in person. We ordered the same kind of tea. It was all going so well. We talked a bit about her writing, and then about me. I didn't know what to say, how to word it. My hands were shaking under the table. I finally just came out with it. "I'm your daughter." And I knew—in that moment, in her eyes—I knew I was wrong.

She comes here on the same day every year because it's the anniversary of her mother's death. It was all just a random coincidence. I thought it was fate. It had to be fate, because everything was fitting together… like the pieces of a puzzle. I thought I was going to meet the woman who gave birth to me. I was so blind that I betrayed the mother who raised me, gave me a home, loved me. I kept my plan a secret from my parents. I orchestrated this whole trip so that I'd be here at the same time she was.

I feel so foolish. I came here on a wild goose chase. I should have accepted the closed adoption and gone on with my life.